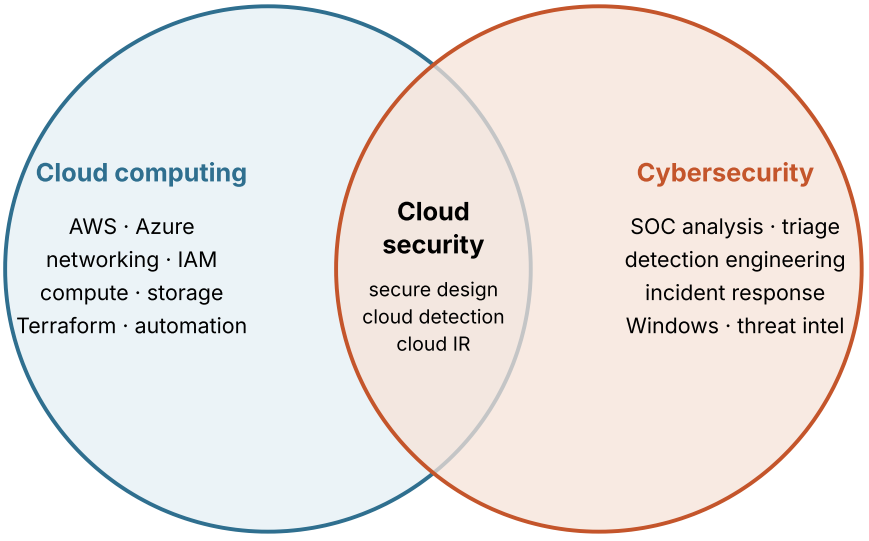
CLOUD SECURITY + BLUE TEAM · DOCUMENT 1 OF 2

The Roadmap

Six months to job-ready cloud security, without dropping blue teaming. 26 October 2026 → 25 April 2027 · AWS first, Azure second · 20+ hours a week · 13 portfolio projects and a capstone.

Prepared for Emmanuel Rukevwe · Version 1 · 24 October 2026



You build skill in both circles. The overlap is where you're heading.

Contents

1 Where you are now
2 Where you'll be in six months
3 The three tracks
4 The six months at a glance
5 Month by month
6 The project portfolio
7 Certifications
8 How you work: the weekly rhythm
9 The lab and the cost rules
10 Job search and visibility
11 Checkpoints and how to adapt
12 After month six
13 Resources

1 Where you are now

> **You're not starting from zero. You've built and debugged a working SOC lab, and that's exactly the evidence employers look for.**

What you've already proven (October 2026)

Area	Evidence
Networking	pfSense with LAN, DMZ and MGMT zones; least-privilege, default-deny rules; aliases; NTP server for the lab
Linux	Ubuntu servers, systemd drop-ins, chrony and timesyncd, SSH key-only login, ufw, Docker
SIEM	Wazuh 4.14 all-in-one: agent deployment, log collection, Ruleset Test, indexer checks
Detection engineering	Rule 5712 brute force proven; custom rule 100100 for low-and-slow guessing, tested both ways
Troubleshooting	Case 001: invisible alerts traced to a 1-hour clock skew; boot-timeout fix; duplicate log source removed
Documentation	A public GitHub repo with phase docs, three case studies, redacted screenshots and an interview bank

What's missing for cloud security roles

Gap	Closed in
Hands-on AWS (IAM, VPC, compute, storage, serverless)	Months 1–3
Infrastructure as code (Terraform) and pipelines	Months 2 and 6
Cloud detection (CloudTrail, GuardDuty, Security Hub)	Month 4
Incident response, in the cloud and on-prem	Month 5
Windows and Active Directory monitoring	Months 3–4
Email/phishing analysis and web attack detection	Month 2
A recognised certification	Security+ (Feb), AWS Solutions Architect Associate (Apr)

2 Where you'll be in six months

> **By 25 April 2027: able to build securely on AWS, detect and investigate attacks in the cloud and on-prem, respond to incidents, and prove all of it with 13 projects, a capstone and two certifications.**

Roles you'll be ready to apply for

Role	Why you'll fit
SOC Analyst (Tier 1–2), especially cloud-focused SOCs	Triage, SIEM, Windows and cloud detections, IR write-ups
Junior Cloud Security Analyst / Engineer	Secure AWS builds, posture assessment, IAM, Terraform pipeline
Cloud Detection & Response / Detection Engineer (junior)	Custom detections for Wazuh and CloudTrail, GuardDuty automation
Cloud Support / Cloud Operations with a security focus	A common first step into cloud teams

"Job-ready" checklist

Cloud

- Design and build a VPC with public and private subnets from memory
- Write and explain least-privilege IAM policies; understand how AWS evaluates them
- Build and destroy environments with Terraform
- Secure S3, EC2, Lambda, APIs and databases
- Explain the shared responsibility model with examples

Blue team

- Triage an alert in under 15 minutes, with a written verdict
- Read Linux, Windows, firewall, web and CloudTrail logs
- Write, test and tune detections; map them to MITRE ATT&CK
- Run an incident from detection to report using the NIST lifecycle
- Investigate a phishing email end to end

REMEMBER

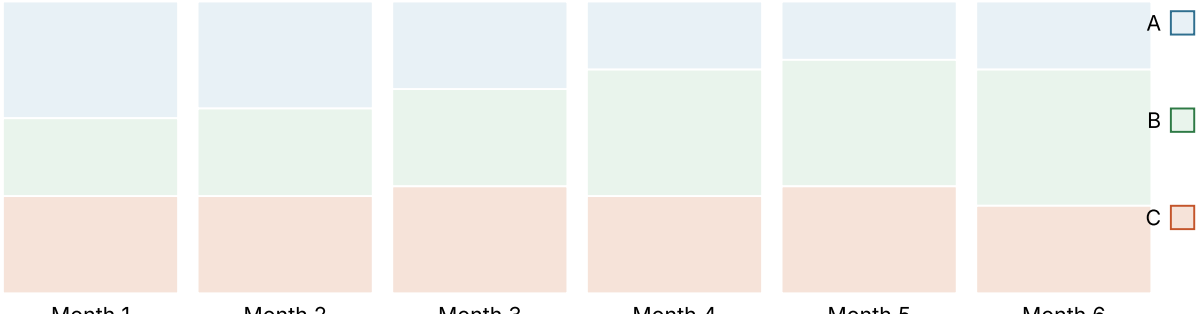
Every item on this checklist is backed by a project in chapter 6. In interviews, you won't say "I know CloudTrail". You'll say "here's the detection I built and the incident it caught".

3 The three tracks

> **Cloud security sits between cloud computing and cybersecurity, so the plan runs three tracks side by side every month. No track is ever dropped; their weight shifts over time.**

Track	What it covers	Typical share of your week
A · Cloud engineering	AWS core services, networking, IAM, Terraform, serverless, containers, Azure basics	High in months 1–2, then about a quarter
B · Cloud security	Secure design, data protection, posture management, cloud detection, cloud IR, DevSecOps	Grows from a quarter to half
C · Blue team	SOC triage, SIEM, detection engineering, Windows/AD, phishing, web attacks, incident response, DFIR basics	About a third, every month

How the weight shifts (approximate share of hands-on time)



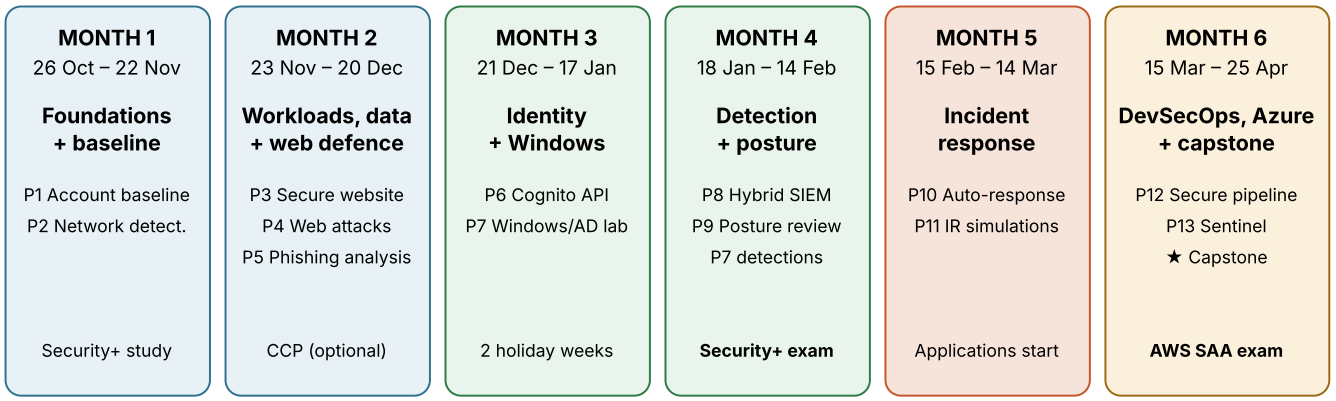
Why the blue-team track never stops

- **Most entry routes into cloud security go through the SOC.** Cloud security teams hire people who already understand alerts, logs and incidents.
- **Detection and response is half of cloud security.** Building securely is prevention; noticing and handling what gets through is the other half.
- **The skills reinforce each other.** Every cloud build in this plan ends with "how would I detect an attack on this?", and every blue-team project uses cloud logs where it can.

IN YOUR LAB

The daily habit that keeps track C alive: **one alert a day** on LetsDefend (or a TryHackMe SOC simulator room), about 20 minutes, with a two-line verdict in your notes.

4 The six months at a glance



Month	A · Cloud engineering	B · Cloud security	C · Blue team
1 · 26 Oct – 22 Nov	Secure account, IAM, VPC, CLI	Account baseline, least privilege, logging on day one	pfSense → Wazuh, scan detection, triage method, TryHackMe SOC L1
2 · 23 Nov – 20 Dec	EC2, S3, CloudFront, Terraform basics	Encryption (KMS), S3 security, WAF	Web attack detection, log analysis, phishing investigation
3 · 21 Dec – 17 Jan	Lambda, API Gateway, DynamoDB	Cognito, IAM deep dive, Organizations + SCPs	Windows Server + AD, Sysmon, Windows event logs
4 · 18 Jan – 14 Feb	Containers (ECR/ECS) light	CloudTrail, GuardDuty, Security Hub, Config, Prowler	Windows/AD detections, threat hunting basics, MITRE coverage
5 · 15 Feb – 14 Mar	EventBridge, Lambda automation	Cloud IR: containment, evidence, recovery	IR lifecycle, playbooks, DFIR basics, CyberDefenders
6 · 15 Mar – 25 Apr	CI/CD, Azure basics	DevSecOps (Checkov, OIDC), Sentinel multi-cloud	KQL, SOAR concepts, interview simulations

5 Month by month

Month 1 · Foundations + a secure baseline (weeks 1–4, 26 Oct – 22 Nov)

> **Goal: an AWS account set up the way a security team would want it, and network attacks visible in your SIEM.**

Track	Learn	Do
A	Regions and AZs, accounts, the AWS CLI, IAM users/roles/policies, VPC, subnets, route tables, gateways	Build a VPC by hand in the console, then with the CLI
B	Shared responsibility, root account protection, MFA, Identity Center, CloudTrail, budgets	**P1 · Secure AWS account baseline**
C	The alert triage method; firewall logs; scanning techniques (MITRE T1046); the SOC tiers	**P2 · Network threat detection**: pfSense logs into Wazuh; TryHackMe SOC Level 1 starts

Done when: P1 and P2 are pushed with write-ups; you can explain an IAM policy line by line; 20+ LetsDefend alerts triaged; Security+ study is under way (about 25%).

Month 2 · Workloads, data + web defence (weeks 5–8, 23 Nov – 20 Dec)

> **Goal: run servers and websites with no exposed admin access and no public buckets, and detect web attacks and phishing.**

Track	Learn	Do
A	EC2, AMIs, EBS, Session Manager, S3, CloudFront, Terraform basics	EC2 in a private subnet with no SSH; first Terraform build and destroy
B	KMS and envelope encryption, S3 Block Public Access, bucket policies, Origin Access Control, WAF	**P3 · Secure static website (S3 + CloudFront + WAF)**
C	OWASP Top 10, web server logs, SQL injection and XSS patterns, email headers, SPF/DKIM/DMARC	**P4 · Web attack detection** (DVWA/Juice Shop → Wazuh) and **P5 · Phishing investigation**

Done when: P3–P5 pushed; every lab resource is Terraform from week 7 on; Security+ about 50%. *Optional: AWS Cloud Practitioner in week 8 (14–20 Dec).*

Month 3 · Identity + Windows (weeks 9–12, 21 Dec – 17 Jan)

> **Goal: master cloud identity (the new perimeter), and build the Windows environment most SOCs monitor.**

Weeks 9–10 (21 Dec – 3 Jan) are lighter holiday weeks at about 10 hours: Windows lab build and Security+ revision only.

Track	Learn	Do
A	Lambda, API Gateway, DynamoDB, serverless design	A small notes API, built with Terraform
B	Cognito, JWTs, OAuth/OIDC, IAM policy evaluation, permission boundaries, Organizations, SCPs, Access Analyzer	**P6 · Secure serverless API with Cognito login**; a 2-account setup with an SCP
C	Windows event logs (4624, 4625, 4688, 4720, 4732), Sysmon, Active Directory basics, Kerberos at a high level	**P7 · Windows/AD SOC lab, part 1**: DC + Windows 11 in a CORP zone, Sysmon, Wazuh agents

Done when: P6 pushed; Windows logs flowing into Wazuh; Security+ practice scores at 80%+, exam booked.

Month 4 · Detection + posture (weeks 13–16, 18 Jan – 14 Feb)

> **Goal: one SIEM watching your home lab and your AWS account, plus a professional posture assessment. Pass Security+.**

Track	Learn	Do
A	ECR and ECS basics (containers in AWS)	Push and run one image; read its vulnerability scan
B	CloudTrail in depth, GuardDuty, Security Hub, AWS Config, CIS AWS Foundations Benchmark, Prowler	**P8 · Hybrid cloud SIEM** (CloudTrail → Wazuh, 5 detections) and **P9 · Cloud posture assessment**
C	Detection engineering for Windows, threat hunting with hypotheses, MITRE ATT&CK coverage	**P7 part 2**: Windows detections tested with safe simulations in your own lab

Done when: P7–P9 pushed; **Security+ passed** (week 15 or 16); a detection coverage map in the repo. AWS Solutions Architect Associate study starts after the exam.

Month 5 · Incident response (weeks 17–20, 15 Feb – 14 Mar)

> **Goal: handle incidents end to end, by hand and automatically, and write reports a manager could act on.**

Track	Learn	Do
A	EventBridge, SNS, Lambda with Python (boto3)	Event-driven automation
B	Cloud IR: containment, evidence (EBS snapshots), credential revocation, recovery from code	**P10 · Automated threat response** (GuardDuty → EventBridge → Lambda) and **P11 · Cloud incident simulations**
C	NIST incident response lifecycle, playbooks, timelines, chain of custody, DFIR basics (disk, memory, log forensics concepts)	Three IR reports; 2–3 CyberDefenders or Blue Team Labs investigations

Done when: P10–P11 pushed; three IR reports with timelines; first job applications sent.

Month 6 · DevSecOps, Azure + capstone (weeks 21–26, 15 Mar – 25 Apr)

> **Goal: security built into the delivery pipeline, a taste of Azure and Sentinel, and one capstone that ties everything together. Pass AWS Solutions Architect Associate.**

Track	Learn	Do
A	GitHub Actions, OIDC federation to AWS, Azure basics (Entra ID, subscriptions, VNets)	A deployment pipeline with no stored keys
B	Policy as code, IaC scanning, multi-cloud SIEM	**P12 · Secure IaC pipeline** and **P13 · Microsoft Sentinel with AWS + Entra ID logs**
C	KQL, SOAR concepts, interview scenarios	★ **Capstone**: a secure 3-tier app with detection and response; mock interviews

Done when: P12, P13 and the capstone pushed; **AWS Solutions Architect Associate passed** (week 26); CV and LinkedIn updated; applications going out every week.

6 The project portfolio

> **Thirteen projects and a capstone, each a public GitHub write-up with a diagram, screenshots, the security decisions and "how I'd detect an attack on this". Step-by-step briefs are in Document 2.**

#	Project	Track	Month	Proves you can…
P1	**Secure AWS account baseline**: MFA, Identity Center, budgets, CloudTrail, account alerts	B	1	Set up cloud accounts safely from day one
P2	**Network threat detection**: pfSense logs → Wazuh, port-scan alerting	C	1	Collect firewall logs and detect reconnaissance
P3	**Secure static website**: private S3 + CloudFront (OAC) + WAF + logging	A/B	2	Publish without public buckets; defend with WAF
P4	**Web attack detection**: DVWA/Juice Shop logs → Wazuh, SQLi/XSS alerts	C	2	Detect application-layer attacks
P5	**Phishing investigation**: header analysis, SPF/DKIM/DMARC, IOC extraction, report	C	2	Handle the most common SOC alert type
P6	**Secure serverless API with Cognito**: MFA, JWT authorizer, least-privilege Lambda, throttling	A/B	3	Build secure login and APIs
P7	**Windows/AD SOC lab**: DC + Windows 11, Sysmon, Wazuh, 5 Windows detections	C	3–4	Monitor the environment most companies run
P8	**Hybrid cloud SIEM**: CloudTrail → Wazuh, 5 tested cloud detections	B/C	4	Detect attacks in AWS with your own rules
P9	**Cloud posture assessment**: Security Hub (CIS), Config, Prowler, remediation report	B	4	Assess and fix an AWS account like a consultant
P10	**Automated threat response**: GuardDuty → EventBridge → Lambda (isolate, notify)	B	5	Automate detection and response
P11	**Cloud incident simulations**: leaked key, public bucket, compromised EC2	B/C	5	Run incidents end to end and report them
P12	**Secure IaC pipeline**: Terraform + Checkov + GitHub Actions with OIDC	A/B	6	Shift security left
P13	**Multi-cloud SIEM**: Microsoft Sentinel with AWS and Entra ID logs, KQL rules	B/C	6	Work in Azure and Microsoft's SIEM
★	**Capstone**: secure 3-tier app + central logging + detections + auto-response + an end-to-end incident	All	6	Put it all together

P3, P6 and P10 are the three projects from the video you shared (S3 + CloudFront + WAF; Cognito login; GuardDuty + Lambda), each extended with a blue-team angle: what to log, what to alert on, and how you'd investigate.

Every project write-up has the same shape

1. **Summary:** what, why, and the result in three lines.
2. **Architecture diagram.**
3. **Build:** the key steps and code (Terraform in `infra/`).
4. **Security decisions:** each control and the risk it addresses.
5. **Test it:** how you proved it works (and safely tried to break it, in your own environment).
6. **Detect it:** the logs and alerts that would show an attack.
7. **Lessons and next steps.**
8. Redacted screenshots; cost per hour; how to destroy it.

7 Certifications

Cert	When	Why	Study load
CompTIA Security+	**Week 15–16** (1–14 Feb 2027)	The most widely requested entry security cert for HR filters, in the UK and Europe too. It covers the blue-team theory.	About 2 h a week from week 1, then 4 h in weeks 13–15
AWS Solutions Architect – Associate	**Week 26** (19–25 Apr 2027)	Proves you can design on AWS: the foundation for cloud security roles. It's the best-known AWS associate cert.	About 4 h a week from week 16
AWS Cloud Practitioner	Week 8 *(optional)*	A quick confidence boost; skip it if time is tight	Mostly covered by months 1–2

After month six

Next cert	For
AWS Certified Security – Specialty	The cloud security cert (aim: late 2027)
Microsoft SC-200 or AZ-500	Azure security operations or engineering
Practical blue-team certs (e.g. BTL1, CySA+)	Hands-on SOC proof; optional

REMEMBER

Check current exam versions, objectives and prices on the official sites before booking. Book the exam date early: a fixed date is the best study motivator.

8 How you work: the weekly rhythm

> **About 21 hours a week, in a repeatable pattern, with one full rest day. Document 2 fills each slot for all 26 weeks.**

Day	Time	Block
Monday	2.5 h	**Cloud build** (track A/B)
Tuesday	2.5 h	**Theory + exam study** (reading, videos, flashcards)
Wednesday	2.5 h	**Blue-team lab** (track C)
Thursday	2.5 h	**Cloud build** (track A/B)
Friday	2 h	**Practice**: exam questions + TryHackMe/LetsDefend
Saturday	6 h	**Project day**: finish the week's project piece, write up, push
Sunday	30 min	**Rest** + plan next week; review session with Claude when you can
Every day	20 min	**One alert** triaged on LetsDefend (two-line verdict)

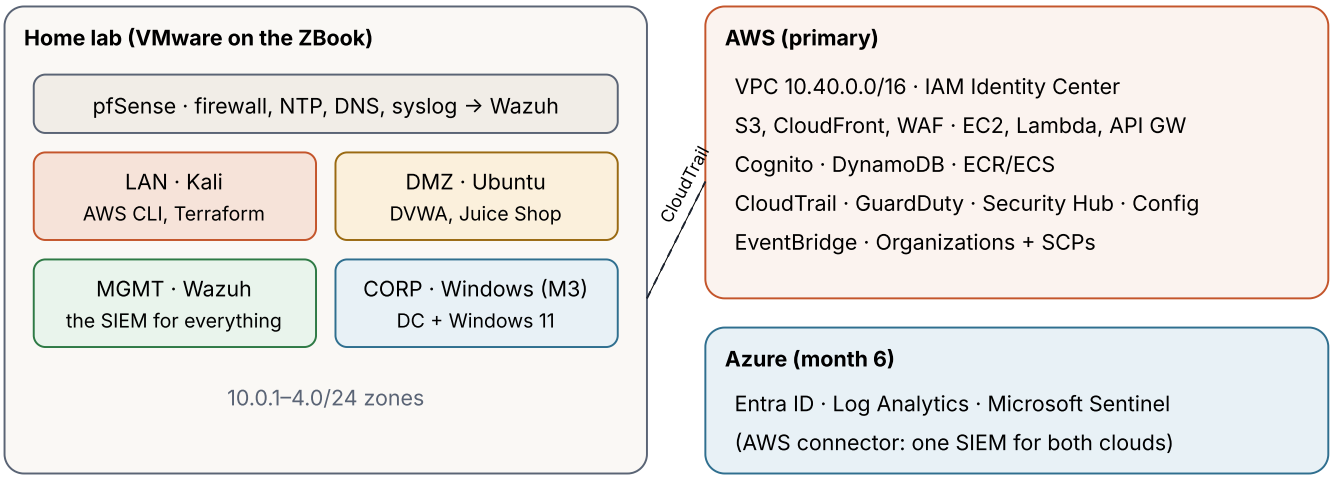
Two-week sprints

The 26 weeks form 13 sprints. Each sprint starts with a 30-minute plan (copy the "done when" list into `progress-log.md`) and ends with a review: push to GitHub, a quiz and explain-back session, and a three-line retro (what worked, what didn't, what to change).

Rules that keep you fast

- **Build the same day you learn.** Theory without hands-on fades in days.
- **Finished beats perfect.** A small project pushed is worth more than a big one half-done.
- **Break it on purpose.** Troubleshooting is the skill interviews test most.
- **One course per cert.** Switching courses halfway wastes weeks.
- **Ask early.** Stuck for 45 minutes? Write down what you tried and ask.

9 The lab and the cost rules



Cost rules (non-negotiable)

1. **Root account:** MFA on, then never used day to day.
2. **Budgets:** a zero-spend alert and a $5 alert before anything else.
3. **Destroy after every session.** From week 7, everything is Terraform, so `terraform destroy` is one command.
4. **Watch hourly-billed services:** NAT gateways, load balancers, RDS, interface endpoints, WAF web ACLs.
5. **Start free trials in the month you use them:** GuardDuty and Security Hub in month 4, Sentinel in month 6.
6. **No access keys in Git or screenshots.** No vulnerable apps in the cloud; they stay in your DMZ.

AWS currently gives new accounts up to $200 of credits on a 6-month free plan, and Azure for Students gives free credit with a school email. Check the current offers when you sign up. Keep Azure for month 6.

10 Job search and visibility

When	Action
Month 1	LinkedIn headline: "Cloud Security & SOC | AWS | Wazuh | Building in public". Pin the GitHub repo.
Every 2 weeks	One post about a project: the problem, what you built, one lesson, a redacted screenshot
Month 3	A 2-page CV draft built around projects (UK style: no photo, achievements first)
Month 4	After Security+: update the CV; start connecting with SOC and cloud security people at target companies
Month 5	**Start applying**: SOC analyst, junior cloud security, cloud support roles (Nigeria, remote, international). Aim for 5–10 quality applications a week.
Month 6	Mock interviews (technical + behavioural); capstone demo video on LinkedIn; continue applying

Your interview story in one line

REMEMBER

"I built a segmented SOC lab and a secure AWS environment, connected them to one SIEM, wrote and tested my own detections, and handled simulated incidents end to end. Here are the write-ups."

If a job or internship arrives early, **take it**. The plan slows down, but real experience counts for more than any month of lab work.

11 Checkpoints and how to adapt

Checkpoint	Date	On track if...
CP1	22 Nov 2026 (end of week 4)	P1 + P2 pushed; IAM and VPC explained from memory; Security+ about 25%
CP2	20 Dec 2026 (end of week 8)	P3–P5 pushed; Terraform working; Security+ about 50%
CP3	17 Jan 2027 (end of week 12)	P6 pushed; Windows logs in Wazuh; Security+ practice 80%+, exam booked
CP4	14 Feb 2027 (end of week 16)	P7–P9 pushed; **Security+ passed**
CP5	14 Mar 2027 (end of week 20)	P10–P11 pushed; three IR reports; applications started
CP6	25 Apr 2027 (end of week 26)	P12, P13 and the capstone pushed; **AWS SAA passed**; applying weekly

If you fall behind: what to cut, in this order

1. The optional Cloud Practitioner exam.
2. P13 (Sentinel). Move it to after month six.
3. Containers in month 4. Read about them and skip the build.
4. Merge P4 into P2's write-up as a smaller section.
5. Move the SAA exam to May 2027.

Never cut: the daily alert, P1, P8, P10, P11, the capstone, Security+. They're the core of the cloud security + blue team story.

If you're ahead

- Add flaws.cloud and flaws2.cloud (legal AWS security challenges).
- Add a detection-as-code repo with tests.
- Start AWS Security Specialty reading early.

12 After month six (May – Dec 2027)

Period	Focus
May – Jul 2027	Deeper cloud security: multi-account landing zone, data security (Macie, Object Lock), container and Kubernetes security; more detections
Aug – Oct 2027	AWS Certified Security – Specialty; Azure security (Defender for Cloud, Entra ID Conditional Access)
Nov – Dec 2027	Second capstone, job sprint, then graduation in early 2028

Revisit this roadmap at CP6 and write version 2 with what you've learned about yourself and the job market.

13 Resources

For	Free	Paid (pick one, optional)
AWS	AWS Skill Builder (free courses), AWS documentation, Well-Architected Framework, AWS security blog	One well-reviewed SAA course + one practice-exam set
Terraform	HashiCorp tutorials (developer.hashicorp.com)	
Cloud security practice	flaws.cloud, flaws2.cloud; AWS Security Reference Architecture; Prowler docs	
SOC practice	LetsDefend (free tier), TryHackMe free rooms, CyberDefenders, Blue Team Labs Online	TryHackMe subscription (SOC Level 1)
Security+	Professor Messer's videos and notes	One practice-exam set
Detection	MITRE ATT&CK (incl. the cloud matrix), Wazuh documentation, Sigma rules repository	
Incident response	NIST SP 800-61 Rev. 3, AWS Security Incident Response Guide	
Azure	Microsoft Learn (AZ-900 and SC-200 paths); Azure for Students	
Your own references	Guides 1–3 (networking, virtualization, cloud foundations) and the Theory Book stay useful as reading. **These two documents replace the older roadmap and sprint workbook.**	

REMEMBER

Only attack systems you own or have written permission to test. Every simulation in this plan runs in your own home lab or your own AWS account.